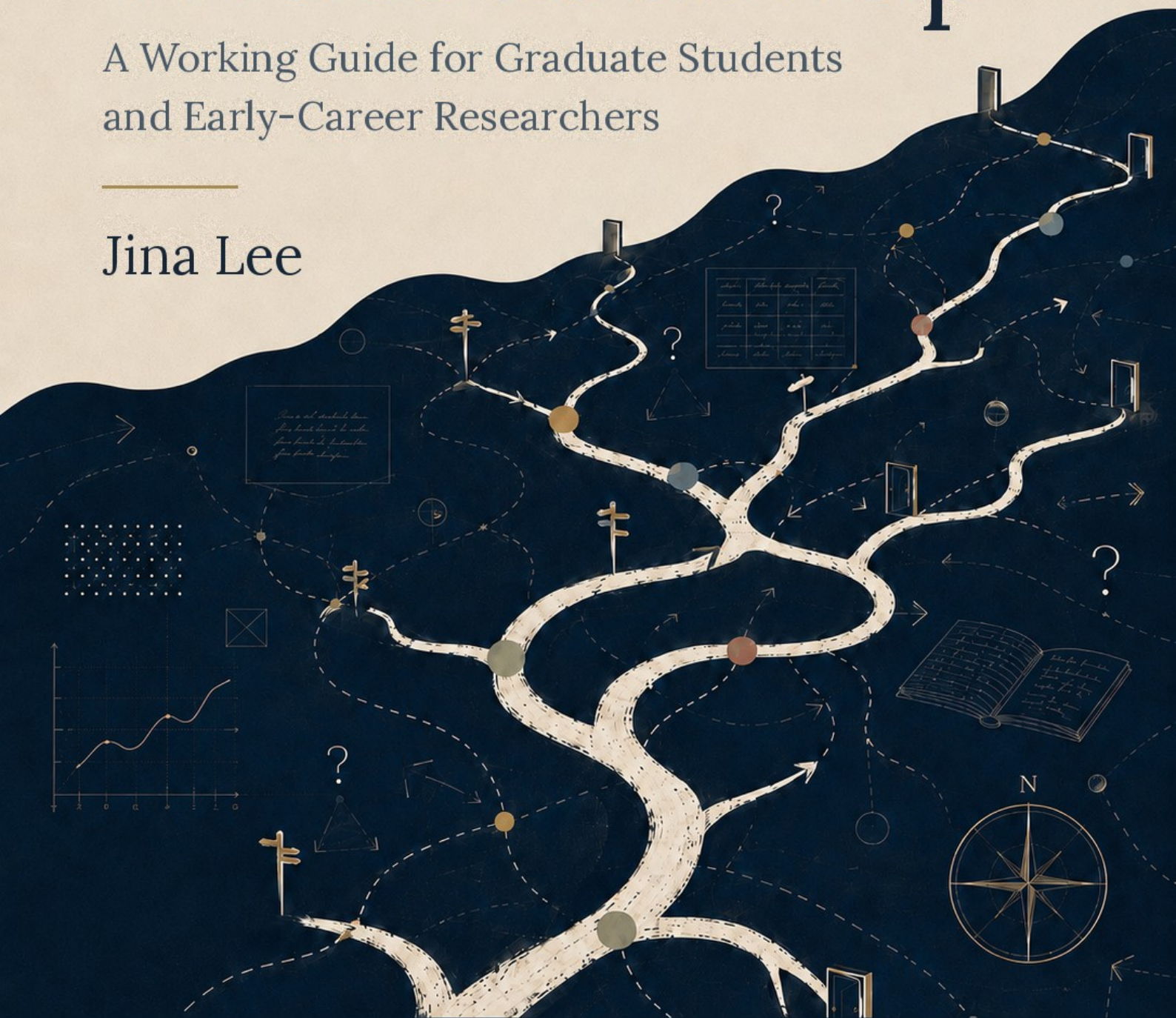


# Navigating Academia Without a Map

A Working Guide for Graduate Students and Early-Career Researchers

Jina Lee



## Contents

Prologue: The Next Move, Not the Right Answer

Find the Chapter You Need

A Glossary of U.S. Academic Terms

1. Enter, Stay, or Change Course

2. How to Choose What to Research

3. Turning What You Read into an Argument

4. Finishing Projects That Never End

5. Whose Advice, and How Far

6. Turning Rejection and Evaluation into a Next Move

7. Reading the Rules No One Writes Down

8. Building an Academic Life You Can Sustain

Worksheets: The first 48 hours after a rejection • Meeting prep card • Project stop checklist •

Conference selection checklist • End-of-semester review • Talk and Q&A prep card • First-

year faculty checklist • Program offer comparison table • Working backward from an

evaluation deadline

Closing: A Decision Is a System, Not an Event

About the Author

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## Prologue: The Next Move, Not the Right Answer

Academia has no right answers. Whether to go to graduate school, whether to keep pushing the question you are working on now, how far to follow your advisor's advice, how much to revise a manuscript that came back rejected. None of those questions has one. Academia is hard because the information contradicts itself, the rules that matter go unstated, and the results come back late. So what matters is how you decide under incomplete information, and how you revise that decision once more of it arrives.

I wrote this book for social science graduate students at U.S. research universities. The reader I pictured most often is about two years into a PhD, at the point where the project, the advising relationships, and the career decisions all begin arriving at once. If you are still weighing whether to apply, or working through a first year as an assistant professor, you can take just the chapters that fit you.

Every chapter is built the same way. It works out what the problem really is, clears away the misreadings people bring to it, sets the criteria for judging, builds a tool you can use straight away, and closes with a next action you can take today. I have added cases so you can see how the principles work inside a real decision. The ones I lived through myself I have written with the details pared back. The rest are hypotheticals, assembled from situations I have heard described to me again and again. Each case is marked so you know which kind it is.

The criteria I propose here came out of problems I ran into, and watched other people run into, over a sociology PhD in the United States and the first stretch of an assistant professorship. That is why U.S. social science graduate programs and research universities keep coming up. I have also tried not to write up my own habits and working style as though they were the right answer. I kept only the criteria and procedures I could use more than once, and where something shifts by field, by country, or by career stage, I have tried to flag it separately. I believe good advice leaves the choosing to you and helps you see clearly what your choice rests on.

I wrote this book in Korean first, for Korean students doing PhDs in the United States. Those were the readers I had in mind: people who read and write in English all day but did not grow up inside this system, and who often have no one to ask about the parts nobody writes

down. That turned out not to be only a Korean problem, so I made this English edition. If you came into a U.S. program from somewhere else, I hope some of it is useful.

If graduate school is the decision in front of you, I would start with Chapter 1 and Worksheet 8. Choosing a program means laying its reputation, its research conditions, where its graduates end up, and the rest side by side, then reading them together.

Early in a PhD, Chapters 2, 3, 5, and 7 will do the most for you. They also come in a workable order: cut the question down, turn the literature into an argument, then learn to read advice and tacit knowledge.

In the middle and later years of a PhD, I would point you to Chapters 4, 5, 6, and 8. When projects, relationships, and evaluations arrive together, those chapters help you sort what to finish from what to stop.

If you are a postdoc or in your first years as an assistant professor, I would suggest picking out Chapters 4 and 8 along with Worksheets 7 and 9. You can use them to protect your research time, to plan backward from the date you will be evaluated, and to build a way of working that will still hold next semester.

This book does not stand in for legal, immigration, medical, or employment advice. Where the real conditions vary, as they do with visas and employment, internships, leaves of absence, journal policies, and tenure, you need to confirm the specifics with the responsible office at your institution, with the official regulations, or with a qualified professional.

What's in this book is my personal view and does not represent the official position of my institution.

## **Find the Chapter You Need**

**Go to Chapter 1 when you are weighing graduate school, or starting to prepare an application abroad. When several programs have admitted you and you have to compare them across a set of conditions. When you have to decide between staying in academia and looking at another path. When the time you have already put in feels too precious to waste, so the decision keeps sliding. When you cannot tell at what point a plan B should start.**

**Go to Chapter 2 when you have many interests and no research question. When the question is too large, or no data you can reach will answer it. When you are pulled between a topic that is in fashion and one you have wondered about for years. When your separate papers do not line up into a single research direction.**

**Go to Chapter 3 when you have read a great deal and still cannot start the introduction. When the literature review reads like a stack of article summaries. When you have results and find it hard to say what makes them matter. When you have to prepare the opening minute of a talk and plan how you will handle the questions afterward.**

**Go to Chapter 4 when the paper is permanently in progress and never finishes. When projects have piled up and the next action is not visible. When co-author roles and author order are unclear. When you have to sort the projects to carry on with from the ones to let go.**

**Go to Chapter 5 when your advisor and your mentor tell you different things. When showing unfinished work frightens you. When you have to voice a different view without damaging the relationship. When you cannot tell which information is useful advice and which is gossip.**

**Go to Chapter 6 when a rejection or a harsh set of comments has landed. When you have to decide how much to revise the manuscript and where to send it next. When the outcome of a review feels like a measure of your worth as a researcher. Worksheet 9 goes alongside this chapter when you want to plan backward from the job market or from tenure.**

Go to Chapter 7 when everyone else appears to know the rules already. When you do not know how to start networking. When you cannot judge how much time conferences, email, and visibility deserve. When gaps in information and opportunity feel like a shortfall in you.

Go to Chapter 8 when a slump and a signal to change direction look the same from inside. When research, teaching, and administration keep expanding without end. When the role and the identity feel unfamiliar after you become a professor. When you doubt that your current way of working could run again next semester.

## A Glossary of U.S. Academic Terms

This book leans on vocabulary that circulates inside U.S. academia. For readers meeting these words for the first time, here is a short gloss of the main ones. Institutions and practices can differ by field and by country, so for the details I'd check with your own institution and its official documents.

- **Rejection.** The journal declines to publish your manuscript.
- **Desk reject.** The editor sends the paper back without putting it out for review.
- **R&R (revise and resubmit).** Review again after revision. A conditional decision: fix it and we will look again.
- **Revision.** The revised manuscript you submit after an R&R, or the work of producing it.
- **Preprint.** A manuscript made public before peer review and publication.
- **The job market.** The hiring market for faculty and research positions, covering everything from application to appointment.
- **Job talk.** The research presentation a candidate gives during a hiring process.
- **Tenure.** A permanent appointment, the secure position you reach once you pass a review.
- **Tenure clock.** The span between appointment and the tenure review.
- **Postdoc.** A research position held after the PhD and before a longer-term appointment.
- **Stipend.** A living allowance paid to a graduate student.
- **Committee.** The dissertation examination committee, made up of your advisor and the other examiners.
- **Proposal.** A research plan, or the process of having that plan reviewed.
- **Defense.** The presentation and examination of a dissertation.
- **SOP (statement of purpose).** The account of your academic and research plans submitted with a graduate application.
- **CV (curriculum vitae).** An academic résumé.

- **RA / TA.** Research assistant and teaching assistant.
- **Cohort.** The students who entered the program in the same year you did.
- **Ethnic tie.** A network formed through shared origin, language, or ethnicity.
- **R1.** The U.S. classification for research universities with the highest level of research activity.
- **Lateral move.** After a rejection, sending the paper to a different journal at the same tier instead of dropping a level.

## 1. Enter, Stay, or Change Course

No single aptitude test settles whether to enter a program, stay in one, or change course. The path is long, the opportunity cost is high, the outcome is uncertain, and at the moment of decision you have most likely not done enough of the real work of academia to know what it is like. This chapter neither recommends academia nor warns you away from it. It makes the costs and conditions of the choice visible, and it sets out criteria you can use to correct your direction after you are already in.

***The core judgment: alongside "do I like research?", ask "which of the difficulties this path demands can I carry, and which conditions, if they broke, would make me change direction?"***

### Ask which difficulties you can live with

Every path has its difficulties. Academia asks for a long training period, income that is low or unsteady, evaluation again and again, rewards that arrive late, and moves from one place to another. Outside academia you bend your work to an organization's goals, you face evaluation and promotion, the work is intense, and your autonomy has limits. A move into a company does not guarantee work-life balance on its own. Stability cannot be the only criterion either. Self-realization, meaning, quality of life, time with family, and health all belong on the same scale, and every choice carries trade-offs. That leaves one question to ask. Which kind of difficulty fits my priorities better?

Write the appeal and the cost on the same sheet of paper. The appeal alone turns into romance; the cost alone turns into a list of fears. Enjoying research may not be enough by itself. The real work of a researcher includes reading and thinking, and beside them data cleaning, document writing, revision, administration, teaching, collaboration, and writing applications. In the other direction, disliking uncertainty is not on its own a reason to give up on academia. With the resources and the alternatives to reduce that uncertainty, the same risk can be lived differently.

## **Test research on a small scale before you enroll**

Realistically, no one gets to live through a research career first and then decide whether to enroll. Parts of it you can test on a small scale beforehand. The most direct version is anything that takes you from settling on a question through gathering material to rewriting a draft: an undergraduate research assistantship, an independent research project, a master's thesis, a short data project. Publishing the result isn't necessary. You're watching for two things. Whether the interest you started with survives data cleaning and round after round of revision with something left over, and whether you can ask for help and begin again when you stall.

## **What to check before you enroll**

Before you apply, look into where a program's recent graduates went and how many years of funding it supports. With a possible advisor, don't stop at the name; check how much real work they have done with their recent students. Where you can, ask current students or recent graduates how often they meet, how fast feedback comes back, and what options remained for students who changed direction midway. The point is to picture one ordinary week of your life in that place before you get there.

A PhD commits you to five to ten years of your life. Some questions deserve an answer before the first application goes out. Why a PhD? Because research appeals to you, because it postpones the job search, or because the people around you expect it? What do you want to be doing afterward? Can you absorb five to ten years of financial instability? Can you sit alone with the work for long stretches, and live through months when nothing moves? Set those years against the practical experience you'd have built by entering the workforce five years sooner. Which is worth more to you? You could also study part-time instead of enrolling full-time, or take a job first, build experience, and come back to the decision later. If you haven't given those alternatives serious thought yet, the reason why is the place to start.

"Studying is fun" and "living as a researcher" are two different stories. The second one brings competition, uncertainty, financial constraint, and unrelenting pressure to prove yourself. If you have worked through these questions and still want it, enrolling is a fine

choice. If the answers haven't come clear, another year or two of thinking it over does no harm.

Even answered honestly, though, these questions leave a part that won't register until you have lived the life itself. So they come close to a minimum condition for being ready, and calling them enough would be a stretch.

Studying abroad adds a few items to the list. Where did that program's graduates actually go over the past five years? Much of the humanities and social sciences works with a narrow market, and in some fields several hundred people compete for one faculty position, so counting on talent alone to carry you is risky. Are you ready to spend five to ten years in another country? Can you carry the economic opportunity cost of getting by on a stipend close to a minimum income, and the sense of deprivation that comes from falling behind your peers on conventional life milestones? Finding any of this out after you enroll is too late.

A master's can work as a limited trial run for a PhD. The risk in time and money, though, isn't always small. Where tuition is high and financial support is close to nonexistent, even a short degree carries a large opportunity cost. Fix the purpose first, whether that's preparing for a PhD, switching fields, or building job skills, then compare the degree against cheaper ways of testing the same thing. A research assistantship, an independent project, or a part-time degree alongside a job may suit you better. If you do go the master's route, it helps to weigh tuition and living costs, funding support, a repayment plan, the advisor, and graduates' careers all together rather than one at a time.

### **A program gives you more than a degree: a daily life and a sense of how high to aim**

In choosing among programs, look at where students go after they finish and what resources the program supplies. Recent graduates' destinations, the options left to someone who changed direction midway, how long financial support runs, the cost of living, housing conditions. The path taken by someone whose circumstances were close to yours tells you more than the average success story does. Living conditions may look like a small matter at first glance, but sometimes they decide whether you make it. The same amount of support has different real purchasing power from one region to another.

One less advertised asset of a well-regarded program is where people set their sights. In a high-prestige program, considering a top journal first for a manuscript of a given quality is what everyone takes for granted. People pick up the habits of those around them, and the gap between trying for something high and never trying at all widens over the years.

Outside that kind of environment, it helps to aim high on purpose, even with no encouragement from anyone nearby. Aiming every manuscript straight at the very top journals is hard to pull off, though. Alongside the ambition you need a feel for where a manuscript actually stands, and desk rejects, rejections after review, and revisions are how that feel gets built.

### **Separate sunk cost from switching cost**

It's better not to settle the question of stopping on the day your feelings run highest. Straight after a rejection, a conflict, or a night without sleep, every road looks bad. Work out first whether this is a passing shock or a structural problem that keeps recurring. Around the middle of a master's, for instance, it's common to hit a stretch of comparing yourself to your cohort, feeling worse and worse about yourself, and seeing no way forward. That stretch on its own doesn't have to count as a signal to leave. Look instead at whether the aversion to the core work holds after you have rested properly and adjusted the external factors, whether the present conditions could change, and whether you have actually tested an alternative path.

Continuing because the time you have already put in feels too precious to waste is sunk-cost logic. It is equally true that changing direction carries real new costs. Keep the two apart.

The hours behind you aren't coming back, but the money, the skills, and the time a transition would take can all be worked out. A change of direction also differs from a declaration of failure. Research builds skills that other paths put to use: defining a problem, analyzing, writing, managing a project. What delays a switch most is seeing work outside academia only in the abstract. Small experiments such as an informational interview, a short project, or an internship give the alternative some shape, and the quality of your decision rises with it.

An international student needs a plan for leaving as well. Some U.S. PhD programs will grant a master's on the way out, but the timing and the conditions differ from school to school.

Where visa rules and degree-conferral rules run into each other, your options can change, and some programs will not award a new master's to someone who already holds one in the same field. Before you decide, I'd recommend checking your own situation against the department's official regulations and with the international student office.

#### **Where general advice runs out: visas, degree changes, and internships**

Visas, paid internships, leaves of absence, graduation timing, a change of degree: within one and the same school these can come out differently depending on your status and your source of funding. A senior student's experience tells you what to ask, but it rarely holds as a rule you can apply directly to your own circumstances.

Before you act on a changed decision, ask for the department's regulations and the international student office's answer by email, so that you have a record. If the question calls for a legal judgment, take it to a qualified professional. With any important decision, it's better to confirm the regulations in advance.

#### **A plan B doesn't weaken your plan A**

Honestly, I had no plan B whatsoever. I had never properly looked into other careers, so I knew nothing about them. I had a vague sense that I ought to do an internship, but research was the urgent thing right then, and the trade-off felt heavy. So I went all in on academic jobs. Out on the job market, I felt for myself how fierce the competition is, and how little a good paper does for you when there are no positions. Only then did I start thinking about a plan B, and by then it was already too late. No experience in another field, no network, no clear idea of what jobs were even out there. I got lucky and landed a faculty position, but if every application had come back a rejection, I would have had nowhere to turn. It was a dangerous strategy however it came out.

The postdoc market has tiers of its own. A project postdoc sits inside a particular grant or lab, and those positions open up fairly regularly. Fellowship postdocs ask for far more specific expertise, draw fiercer competition, and often close early. Some have deadlines in July or early August and want a research plan covering several years, so without knowing about them ahead of time and preparing, you lose the chance to apply at all.

After that I came to define a plan B differently. It became the information and experience you secure in advance to keep your freedom to choose, in place of an exit you assemble in a

hurry once you have failed. Preparing an alternative can feel like committing less to academia. But with no alternative at all in hand, bad terms are hard to turn down. Having options is what lets you choose your current path more freely too. Giving a whole summer over to research matters, but it doesn't have to be the reason other possibilities stay closed. With academic jobs thinning out the way they have lately, it's safer to keep both going at once.

Preparation works best in the middle of your training. If you wait until something has fallen through, you're already late. In a U.S. social science PhD, the third and fourth years can be a good stretch for exploring careers seriously. The first two years go to learning how to do research, and even so you can use them to watch which paths the students ahead of you took and what moved them to take those paths. Once your direction has settled and you have a couple of years left before you finish, I'd talk with people ahead of you who built careers outside academia, mark the requirements that repeat across postings for jobs you're curious about, and test the skills you lack on something small. Coding and data analysis come up often enough that it's worth doing this for them in particular. Closer to your final year, you prepare two versions of your résumé, an academic CV and an industry résumé, and you write a concrete job market plan. If it's possible and your visa and program rules allow it, an internship or a short applied project once or twice before you graduate is worth doing. Experience like that is one of the few ways to find out whether you want the work, and the industry you picture from inside a lab can look different from the industry itself. Whether it turns you toward something else or convinces you that academia suits you, it gives your next decision something to stand on.

### **Don't make a decision permanent**

The same change lands differently on different people. Someone who says graduate school was better remembers a professor's autonomy as a burden; someone who says life improved after becoming a professor remembers that same autonomy as a privilege. The professors point to pushing the research they want without an advisor's approval, and to getting clear of job market anxiety and an income that never held still. The ones who miss graduate school mind that the advisor who used to set a direction is gone, and that funding, running a lab, and supervising students moved into the space the advisor left. The same

path is lived differently depending on when you are in it and on what you attend to. That is why neither entering nor leaving has to be settled permanently by one decision.

I'd give the decision a review date. Write down now what signal would send you back to it a year from now, what the minimum conditions are for continuing, and what conditions would clearly mean stopping or switching. Written down that way, the decision turns from a single act of resolve into a process you can revise.

### **Decision tool: an entering-and-leaving decision table**

Fill in your own answers to the items in the table below. None of them has a set answer, so a short line that fits where you are now is enough.

| Item                                                                              | Your answer |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Is what I want the degree, the work of research, or the job of being a professor? |             |
| The three most appealing things                                                   |             |
| The three costs hardest for me to carry                                           |             |
| Can I secure funding and living conditions above my minimum standard?             |             |
| Skills and paths I could use if I don't get the outcome I want                    |             |
| A signal that would make me review this decision a year from now                  |             |
| The minimum conditions for continuing                                             |             |
| The clear conditions for stopping or switching                                    |             |

### **What to do now**

1. Read five actual job postings for the path you want and five for your alternative path.
2. Put the appeal, the cost, and the preparation each of the two paths needs side by side on one page.
3. Keep the decision from hardening into a permanent one by setting your next review date and the signals that would mean switching.

## 2. How to Choose What to Research

A research question can stay out of reach for reasons beyond a shortage of ideas. Your interest may be too large, or your question may not connect to data you can actually access, or you may have no standard for weighing what's in fashion against what draws you from the inside. Through a BA and even an MA the route is laid out reasonably well. From the PhD on it isn't. Defining the problem each day, choosing the method, and working out where to go when the path dead-ends all end up being yours to do. A researcher's expertise is the ability to find the problem and define it while the situation is still uncertain.

None of this has to be carried alone, though. The more uncertain your direction, the more a conversation with a colleague, or an exchange inside a research community, gives your judgment a reference point.

***The core judgment: a good question holds an important tension in the literature and still lets you add one step with the data and the methods you have now.***

### Studying and research are different kinds of work

Studying means taking in knowledge that already exists. Research means choosing a question nobody has answered well enough and offering a better explanation from limited evidence. Knowing a lot matters, but it doesn't hand you a research question. People with wide interests sometimes wander longer. In undergrad, interests running in every direction are an advantage; in graduate school, when you try to narrow to one topic, wanting all of them at once slows down your sense of direction. Grad seminars differ from undergrad ones here too. An abstract idea is welcome in undergrad, while grad discussion usually converges on a question you can test. How are you going to measure that? Where will the data come from? How will you test that hypothesis? The constraint is frustrating at first, but it also trains you to filter out ideas that are interesting in theory but impossible in practice.

Advice to think critically needs gradations once you try to practice it. Doubt everything at the same strength and you can accept nothing, and even the minimum confidence you need to move a project forward drains away. Your time and energy are limited, so deciding how far to accept a claim and where to concentrate your doubt is itself a judgment. Looking back at whether your own criteria are reasonable belongs to critical thinking as well. The critical

eye has to turn on your own preferences and biases too, not only on other people's research. That is where the habit comes from of checking yourself for the double standard that runs generous toward theories and methods you like and strict toward the ones you don't. You never find the perfect balance, so some of the time you're too critical to make progress, and some of the time you're too generous and miss something that mattered.

People who keep stalling at the reading stage ask, "how much more do I have to know before I can start?" The more useful question is, "where does the literature I've read so far collide with itself, and what does it fail to explain?" Research questions come out of the tension between explanations as much as out of the blanks in what's known.

### **Cutting a huge interest down to a question you can answer**

Early in a program, the enormous question that will change the world is easy to fall for. Why does inequality persist? Why is politics turning to the far right? Both matter, but both are far too big to answer in one paper. A question you can't answer doesn't become research, however important it is.

A question you can answer meets three conditions. Access to data. However interesting the hypothesis, if you have no data to test it against, that's the end. A workable method. Can you analyze the data with the skills you have now, and if you'd have to learn something new, do you have the time and the resources? The right scope. A question too big won't fit in a whole book, and a question too small won't fill a single paper. When the question is too big, hold it to one mechanism, one turning point, one condition; when it's too small, connect its answer to the larger debate that answer would change.

The search for a question also has concrete moves. As you read published work, mark the point where you think a study is fine work and still leaves some part untouched. And when questions such as "Why is that?" or "Would it hold in another setting?" surface in conversation with a colleague, don't let them drift past you.

And don't wait for the perfect question. If a question satisfies you about 80 percent of the way, it's better to start. The question keeps getting reworked as you go anyway, and the question you began with and the question in the final paper are often nothing alike. Ask only

the safe questions and you contribute nothing; ask only the outsized ones and you never finish.

### **Extended case: turning a research question into a workable hypothesis**

*Case type: hypothetical*

Start with the research question, "Why do disaster-hit places recover at different speeds?"

"Recovery" includes population, employment, local commerce, housing, and well-being, so the question is too broad for one study.

First, narrow the outcome: "Under what conditions do small businesses affected by a disaster reopen?" This is a workable research question. To derive a hypothesis, select one explanation from the literature and turn it into a specific prediction.

Research on local organizations suggests that merchants' associations help members share information and resources. The hypothesis is: "Among businesses facing comparable damage, pre-disaster members of a merchants' association will be more likely than nonmembers to reopen within two years."

The unit is the individual business, the outcome is reopening within two years, and the comparison is pre-disaster membership. Before the full analysis, test whether damage, membership, and operating status can be linked in a small sample. If the necessary data are unavailable, narrow the hypothesis or choose another explanation.

*The question to take away: if I select one explanation from my research question, what specific prediction can I make that the available evidence could prove wrong?*

Sometimes a question you have already settled on has to change partway through. Say you finish the proposal defense, and then something unexpected shifts the whole landscape. The costs of that are concrete. You may have to reassemble the committee, push the defense back, and graduate later. Hesitating is a fair response to the time you have already spent. Even so, cost alone is a hard basis for the decision. You will be living with this project for years, so whether the question is important and interesting enough to carry you through that time counts just as much as the cost. More often than not, a PhD does not run the way it was originally planned.

## **Use trends for framing; set direction by what actually draws you**

The case against chasing only trends is a practical one rather than a principled one. Trends shift again as soon as you chase them, and dissertation topics feel this most. You can start a dissertation on whatever is hot now, and by the time you graduate five or seven years later, some other issue may well have risen in its place. Choose the topic that means the most to you and interests you most, and you keep something to run on when the trend turns; on the hard days you can tell yourself this was the work you wanted to do.

Give the two of them different jobs instead of making them compete. What draws you sets the long-term question; the trend supplies the framing that ties that question to a current debate. A rough read on the trends, picked up a year or two before you go on the job market, helps you decide how to position your work. You still don't hand over to fashion the question you will hold for years.

## **Personal experience starts a question**

An unfamiliar position is a resource for questions. If you have come inside an institution but stand at some distance from the person that institution assumes, you follow the rules and at the same time see who the rules were made for. The sociologist Patricia Hill Collins called this position the "outsider within." Experiences such as migration, a move between fields, a class background, or a career switch make you compare rules that differ, and what looks like a flaw can work as an analytic resource.

Personal experience, though, is a starting point before it is evidence. Experience produces the question; the claim has to be examined with systematic data and methods. So you don't stop at "this is how it felt to me." You move to "for whom, under what conditions, and in what form does this recur?"

## **Putting scattered projects on a map**

For the first several years of grad school I never knew what to research next. There were plenty of interesting topics, but I could not see how they connected, or how to turn any of them into a study. Then, once a few pieces of work had piled up, I put the questions, the cases, and the methods on a single page, and a problem I kept returning to came into view. After that, finding the next project stopped meaning inventing an idea from nothing. It

meant taking a question I had already opened and extending it to other data and other conditions. What I was chewing on changed from "what should I do next" to "which of these should I do first." The road was still long, but it felt like I finally had a map.

This is what people mean by a research program. A research program matters for three reasons. It is efficient, because the literature, the data, and the methods you gain in one study carry into the next. It raises the impact of the work, because several studies that deliver one consistent message can show from several angles a big idea that no single paper could argue on its own. And hiring and tenure review look past the number of papers to the trajectory and the narrative of the research. A good researcher's papers each mean something on their own and together make one story.

A research program works differently from a brand you declare at the outset and then complete. You finish a few projects, look back, and the common threads surface: a question you keep coming back to, a method you use often, a theoretical lens that repeats. Sometimes someone else spots the connection before you do.

The dissertation matters here too. It is the starting point that defines who you are for the next five to ten years, which is a larger job than meeting a graduation requirement. So don't ask only whether it is doable. Ask what follow-up studies grow out of the topic, and how many years you can keep researching it.

A research program can continue even when the object of study does not stay the same. If the question itself recurs over a long stretch, a change of object doesn't break the program. Consider a question about how the criteria that sort who counts as an "excellent" researcher and what counts as "valuable" knowledge come to be socially constructed. That question can stay in place even as the object moves from the arts and culture to academic fields. Where the underlying question holds, an apparent change of direction is the same program getting wider.

### **Novelty comes from a new combination**

It is easy to assume a new idea has to be built from nothing. Usually a new idea comes out of a new combination of elements that already exist. A smartphone joins a telephone, a computer, a camera, and the internet. The most innovative papers tend to arrive the same

way, out of an unusual combination of studies that no one had cited together before. So one route is to connect subfields that rarely meet. Put the lenses of two fields on the same problem and what one field takes for granted becomes an innovation in the other, while the limits of each can cover for the limits of the other. The mindset that helps here is "whatever tool solves this problem is the tool I will use." It has a different grain from "I am a sociologist, so I should use only sociological methods." My own position is that the problem comes first and the method second. Even so, it helps to know at least one field deeply and to have the basics of the other.

### **Setting priorities among ideas**

You want to research more than a 24-hour day holds. Four criteria let you compare new ideas. Feasibility: do you already have the data, or can you get it easily, and can you put a team together? Contribution: is the theoretical contribution clear? Fit with the program: does the idea sit naturally inside your research program and develop that path? What draws you: do you want it enough right now that three years to a first draft and five to publication would not leave you with regrets? An idea that meets three or more of these moves up the priority list. Keep the rest on a holding list instead of throwing them out. The question that is good now and the question that is good later can be two different questions.

Sometimes speed matters. Someone may be answering a similar question with the same public data at the same moment, and academia clearly does tend to concentrate credit on whoever publishes first. What you can do then is finish as fast as you can within the scope you have set, publish, and sharpen the framing and the story. Timing and narrative are sometimes as important as what the analysis found.

### **Use your coursework as a research resource**

Coursework can serve your research too. Set a ceiling on the hours you give to class prep, but treat a methods course as a chance to learn tools you will use for the rest of your career, and write each term paper toward the first draft of a publishable manuscript. Not every term paper becomes an article, but keeping that target in mind is how one of them can end up as a dissertation chapter or a first publication. Coursework also opens a route to relationships with faculty. Ask good questions, go to office hours, put real care into the term

paper, and the class can leave you with a relationship that leads to a co-authored paper or an RA position long after the term ends.

### **Decision tool: a screening sheet for research questions**

For each candidate question, score the items below from 1 to 5.

| Item                                                                          | Score (1-5) |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| If the answer to this question changed, would existing explanations change?   |             |
| Can you turn it into concepts you can observe in data?                        |             |
| Can you design something that separates competing explanations?               |             |
| Can you produce a first result with the time and skills you have now?         |             |
| Does it connect to a long-term research program?                              |             |
| Will you still have the motivation to stay with this question in a few years? |             |

The useful information sits in the low items rather than the total. If importance scores high and feasibility low, narrow the scope. If feasibility scores high and the contribution looks weak, find the connection to a larger debate.

### **What to do now**

1. Write three of your interests out as questions.
2. Under each question, add one line each for the data it needs, the competing explanations, and the minimum result.

### 3. Turning What You Read into an Argument

If you have read a great deal and still cannot write, the trouble may lie in structure more than in the amount of information. Academic writing builds a path where the reader starts from one question, follows the evidence, and arrives at a conclusion different from the ones already on offer. Showing everything you know is a different job. Take a literature review, an introduction, a results section, a discussion, a talk. They look like separate documents, but in fact they are doing the same work. Each one takes a single sentence, "here is what we now know that we did not know before, and here is why it matters," and unfolds it in the grammar of its own genre. This chapter covers how to narrow down what you read, how to turn what you have read into an argument and a structure, and how to carry that argument into your writing and your talks.

***The core judgment: build the one-sentence summary that holds your question and your central claim before anything else.***

#### Read from the forest to the trees

When your background knowledge is thin and you read whatever a keyword search turns up, you end up among the trees with no view of the forest. It helps to set an order. Start with review articles, handbook chapters, and the like, which give you the scope of the field and its central debates. Move to the classics, the ones with overwhelming citation counts or the ones the reviews keep naming, and pick up the shared language there. Then read the last four or five years to see where the field is heading; skimming the abstracts and introductions is enough for that pass. Last, take the studies that connect directly to your own question and your own data, and read those closely, methods and limitations included.

Reading goes wrong in three ways. Perfectionism, the urge to know everything before you begin, keeps you from ever beginning. Digging into the details first inverts the order and costs you the big picture. And passive reading, reading and nothing more, leaves nothing behind. It helps to read with one question in mind and to write down the answer: which part of my own question does this paper change? When the prior work is thin, widen your keywords, search the neighboring fields, and ask the people around you. When there is too much of it, rank the most-cited papers first and lay the field out as a map in a spreadsheet.

One principle covers all of this. Start once you have roughly 80 percent of it, and fill in the rest while the research is under way. The reading and the research need to run side by side.

### **A literature review is where you design tension**

Summarize one paper per paragraph and you accumulate literature without building an argument. Group the studies by approach instead of by date or by author, and open each group with a single sentence: "these studies explain X in terms of Y." Then build the tension between the groups. Once you can show where they collide and which factor all of them pass over, you have a position of your own. You can side with one group, combine two, or name a third factor both of them missed. For the major studies in each group, show how their core logic, their data, and their findings feed your argument, narrowing steadily toward the gap your own research will fill. It runs something like this: you take the structural approach, then the rational-choice approach, show that neither one accounts for culture, and arrive at the point where cultural scripts matter and the empirical work is thin. Between groups and between paragraphs, connectors like "by contrast," "unlike these," and "moving beyond this debate" keep the flow smooth.

The last sentence of a literature review has to reach past "there is little research on this."

The gap you name can be small, but it has to be substantive. That a topic has not been studied enough is not a reason on its own. Say why the hole matters theoretically, and why the existing approaches could not answer it.

### **Short case: turning a list of papers into the structure of a debate**

*Case type: hypothetical*

Say your literature review, before revision, runs like this. It summarizes study A, then B, then C, and closes with "this topic has not been studied enough." A reader can see what else we would need to know, but not which of the existing explanations has to change.

In the revision the literature splits into two groups. The first explains outcomes through the resources available and the institutional constraints; the second puts the weight on individual preferences and choices. You then point out that neither explanation handles how people read the same set of options differently. The room for a new study comes from the angle neither explanation covered, not from the scarcity of research.

*The question to take away: if I sort the literature I have read into two or three groups of explanations, what do those groups still leave unexplained?*

### **An introduction argues that the paper is necessary**

An introduction is where you persuade the reader that this paper is needed. A good one usually follows the same order: open the research problem, set out the tension or the gap in prior work, raise the stakes by showing why that gap matters, state what the study asks and how it answers, compress the central claim and the findings, and specify what it adds and to which literature.

In empirical papers in the U.S. social sciences, a good place to open is why X is still unexplained, or in what respect it remains unexplained. Even while you lay down the background, it helps to plant the seed of the tension: "X developed this way. But Y is still a problem." When you introduce the data and the methods, put the weight on what they let you see rather than on what you did. And when you preview the key results, I'd recommend going as far as where the effect appears and where it disappears, and under which conditions it changes. If your target journal's conventions run differently, follow the journal.

The introduction also needs a punch line somewhere, one line that compresses what the paper does. Aim for the sentence a reader still has in mind once the introduction ends. When that one-line summary wobbles, the scope of the literature review wobbles with it, and so does the scope of how you read your results. Sentences like "this has drawn a great

deal of attention recently" or "this study has implications" carry no information. Every sentence in an introduction should be one the introduction needs.

This order is closer to a standard form, though, and the working style has hardened differently in each field and each journal. Read the introductions of three or four recent papers in the journal you are aiming at and pin down the grammar it actually follows; that is the safer route.

### **The discussion is where you argue the implications**

The most common mistake in a discussion is a second summary of the results. Summarize the analysis once, briefly, and give the space that remains to implications. The discussion's job is to say what the results mean and why they matter. Instead of repeating that the study is important, write specifically about which debate in which literature it contributes to, and how. Does it extend an existing explanation, restrict the conditions under which it holds, or add a new mechanism? Take the limitations past general lines like "the sample is small" to what this particular design keeps you from interpreting, and take the future directions past "more research is needed" to which question, by which method, and why.

Guarding against overgeneralization also belongs to the discussion. Keep the range of application explicit instead of stretching a result from one context and one sample to every case. The sharper the boundary between what the study shows and what it does not, the more trust the claim earns. Keep the structure plain: summary, contribution, implications, limitations, future research.

### **A talk compresses the same argument**

The one-sentence claim you built on the page also sets the order of your talk. Compress the central puzzle and the question into the first thirty seconds. A broad introduction to the topic can wait. Sort the questions you expect into claim, data, method, scope, and alternative explanations, and prepare each group. Worksheet 6 sets out how to design a hook and how to handle the questions when they come.

### **Decision tool: the one-sentence claim canvas**

Complete the five sentences below, filling in the blanks in order.

| Sentence frame                                                              | My sentence |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| Phenomenon: We know that ( ).                                               |             |
| Tension: But ( ) is still unexplained.                                      |             |
| Question: This study asks ( ).                                              |             |
| Answer: Using ( ) data and methods, it argues that ( ).                     |             |
| Contribution: This claim changes the ( ) explanation in the ( ) literature. |             |

If the five sentences do not follow from one another naturally, find the break in the chain before you write any more sentences.

### What to do now

1. Move your literature off the author-by-author list and re-sort it into three or fewer groups of claims.
2. Finish the one-sentence claim canvas before you write the introduction.
3. Set your abstract, the last paragraph of your introduction, and the first minute of your talk side by side, and check whether the same central claim runs through all three.

## 4. Finishing Projects That Never End

In academic work the external deadlines are weak, or they sit too far off. A goal the size of "write the paper" will not produce a schedule. Finishing a project means putting the pieces where you can see them: where the project stands now, what its next action is, what counts as done, and the condition on which you would stop. This chapter is about telling the projects you will finish apart from the ones you will drop, and about moving each of them one step at a time.

***The core judgment: separate the projects you will finish from the ones you will drop, and manage each one so that it moves a single step at a time.***

### **The more time you have, the less you focus**

You would expect a stretch of open time to raise your output automatically. It often works the other way. During the semester your time comes in slivers. Classes, assignments, TA work, and seminars cut the day into pieces, and the research happens in the gaps. It feels cramped, and yet the shortage sometimes sharpens your focus. Over a break the whole day is yours, and with that much of it the thought that it can wait until later takes hold, so a break can turn out less productive than the semester.

So the more open your time is, the more you need an artificial structure. Fix a start time and an end time so the day has working hours, and build the plan backward from the deadline. Setting out to do all of this and all of that over a long break mostly fails, so a realistic target, on the order of finishing this one paper over this break, works better. A plan you can keep is worth more than a perfect one. In the time blocks themselves, put tasks you can finish rather than a lump like "work on paper." Sorting ten references, or writing two paragraphs of explanation for a results table, is work you can finish in thirty minutes to two hours. Regular check-ins with your advisor or a colleague also manufacture a deadline where there was none.

### **The gap between plan and reality is data**

I have been tracking my working hours for some years now. The method is simple. Each project gets its own color in Google Calendar; I block out in advance the time I mean to give

it that day, and once I have worked I go back and trim the block down to the hours I was fully focused. At first it served as self-surveillance, a way to see which days I had failed to keep the plan. Then the data accumulated and a more important pattern surfaced. Work moved further on days with limited time blocks than on days with an empty calendar, and the gap between plan and reality turned less on willpower than on the size of the task and the cost of switching between tasks. From then on the point of the records changed, from watching myself to correcting my plans.

### **Short case: changing the purpose of time tracking from self-surveillance to better planning**

*Case type: my own experience, details simplified*

I expected a wholly open day over the break to be good for long stretches of manuscript work. My records said the opposite. The same shape kept repeating: a late start, drifting between one task and another, and a short total of focused time. The days that moved the work along had only one or two limited blocks wedged between meetings, because those days made me settle in advance on a unit of work I could finish in a short stretch.

From then on I stopped treating the log as a scorecard for hours worked. What I read it for instead was whether the task I had planned was bigger than the block I gave it, whether I kept switching, and what size of block to try the following week. That gap between plan and reality was what I built the next plan out of.

*The question to take away: which of the plans I missed this week are explained by the size of the task or the cost of switching, rather than by willpower?*

If you want to try time tracking, I'd suggest keeping the first version simple. People often abandon it while trying to build the perfect system. Don't split things finely; a few broad categories such as research, teaching, and admin are enough to start with, and you can get more specific once the habit holds. A calendar you already keep in detail will do on its own, and a dedicated app suits you better if you want the logging automated from the start. If you miss a few days, you can just start again. Patterns show up once the data piles up, and that is when it starts to be useful.

## Mark each project with its stage

"In progress" covers far too much ground. When a project that is still only an idea sits on the same list as one with a finished draft, you have no way to set priorities. A paper moves through a long series of stages: an idea, the literature, and a data source in hand; an outline and data collection finished; a full draft with results in it; a conference presentation; submission to a journal; R&R; resubmission; publication. Every paper you have sits somewhere on that ladder.

Two things make this work. One is that the current stage of every project sits on a single screen. The other is that you write out concretely what ends a stage. Write "done when the three main models and the robustness checks are laid out in tables" instead of "analyzing," and the next action that moves the project gets smaller. [Political scientist Matthew Lebo's system goes one step further](#). You score the stages each project has left, divide the total by the number of months until your tenure file is due, and that gives you the score you have to clear each month. A huge goal turns into daily micro-goals you can manage.

When several projects are running at once, it helps to give up on advancing all of them every week. Hold the list of projects that will move one stage this month to one or two. A project whose publishability you have confirmed is worth sending on to a journal instead of stopping at the conference presentation. A manuscript you presented and never submitted becomes a debt that keeps draining the value out of the time you have already put into it. (If a fatal problem has surfaced in the question or the data, though, it's better to accept the sunk cost and stop.)

On a first project, start small and put finishing ahead of everything else. A master's thesis, for instance, is there to teach you how to do research; Nobel-worthy work is not the assignment. Borrow the design of an existing study and change only the case, and you are following a procedure that has already been tested, so your risk of a disaster is low. If instead you start from something you have been personally curious about, the motivation lasts longer, but then you have to check for yourself whether the question is one data can answer. Either way, starting small and carrying it through to the end is better than getting stuck partway into something entirely new and never writing it. Ask "how could I study

this?" instead of "can this be a research topic?" and the route opens up more often than you'd expect.

### **Co-authorship is an operating system**

A good co-author is the person who finishes the project. Brilliance counts for less. With a fellow graduate student, track record is what matters most. Do they finish? Do they keep deadlines and promises? Do they work through the tedious parts without complaint?

Intellectual overlap, complementary skills, and taking feedback without getting defensive come after that, and since no co-author is perfect, it helps to start from that premise and acknowledge what each of you is good and bad at.

With a faculty co-author, look at whether their interest in your idea is real, whether they bring the expertise and the network to lift the project, and whether they reflect a student's contribution fairly in the author line.

#### **Balancing co-authorship and solo authorship**

Joining as a co-author on a study that is already largely finished is one route. But if you don't yet have a single solo-authored paper, you may be better off finishing one on your own; the solo-authored paper still counts on the job market, though this varies by field.

Author order is awkward to bring up, but it's still better to discuss it in advance where you can. Conventions differ by field, and even in fields where order follows contribution, how that contribution gets measured is itself largely unspoken. A student has a particularly hard time raising it first when a senior-junior relationship is involved. Even so, it helps to put author order, expectations, and the division of labor on the table when the work begins, on the condition that you will discuss it again if contributions change as you go. It isn't a perfect method, but it's the fairest route, and less uncomfortable than the alternative.

#### **Where general advice runs out: authorship and data ownership**

Author order, permission to use the data, where the code and materials are kept, and how far you may use them after you leave a project are hard to work out from field convention alone. Bargaining power is also unequal, particularly between a student and a professor, or between the principal investigator on a grant and a researcher they employ.

At the start, put every author's role and the work expected of them in writing where you can. If a conflict comes up, weigh the advice of a mentor you trust who has no stake in the matter together with your institution's research ethics and data policies. And if contributions have changed in the meantime, discuss it again on the basis of the work as it actually went, instead of giving the first agreement priority.

### **Pick the target journal and the stopping rule early**

Finishing the whole paper and then wondering where to send it is inefficient, because journals differ in the style they prefer. In sociology, for one, the higher the journal the more weight a theoretical contribution carries, while a mid-tier journal is often satisfied with a solid empirical contribution, and that difference changes the way you write the paper itself.

How strong that tendency is varies by field. Settle on an ideal target, a realistic target, and a safe option at the outset, then read recent papers in those journals to learn what they expect and how they sound, and the decisions you make while writing come easier.

Assess your own data coldly, and let that set the tier. This varies by field, but a small-sample pilot study may be a stretch for the very top journals, while large-scale longitudinal data collected over several years is worth an attempt.

Keep a journal's prestige and its fit apart as well. However good the journal, a topic and method outside its scope only raise your chance of a desk reject. If you have a graduation or job market timeline to meet, look at average review times; if time is looser, consider moving on to another journal at a similar tier after a rejection and trying again.

It also helps to set the stopping rule when the project starts. How long you have worked on something and whether you have reason to continue are separate questions. When the following signs keep repeating, it is worth reviewing whether to stop or redesign: when you learn the research question itself is flawed or has already been answered well enough; when you try other methods and other data and still nothing comes out; when the value of the result is far too small for the resources it takes; when another team is well ahead of you with the same approach and you have no route to differentiate your project. Settling these before your feelings get involved can keep you from clinging later. Ending a project looks like failure, but it can be a decision that moves your resources onto a more valuable question. Ending hurts less, too, when you distinguish among total abandonment, a pause, reusing the materials, and narrowing or changing the question.

## Extended case: whether to continue an old project or redesign it

*Case type: hypothetical*

Suppose you have been holding on to a project for nearly two years. The question matters, but the way you measure the key variable keeps shifting, and every new analysis sends the result in a different direction. While that was going on, a study using data better suited to a similar question came out first. So much time has gone in that letting go feels like failure.

Start by refusing to let the options be only "continue" and "quit." Break them apart: keep going with the same question and data, narrow the question, redesign with different data, hold it for a set period, or end it outright. Under each one, write down the time it still needs, the skills you would have to learn, the contribution that would set it apart from the study already out, and the effect on your next evaluation.

Written out, it looks as though the current design can't solve the measurement problem that keeps returning, and gathering new data would push graduation back badly. One part of the existing data, though, looks as though it could answer a smaller methodological question. That opens up another choice: end the original paper, collect the code and literature notes you can reuse, and switch to a new project with a narrower question.

It helps to write down why you stopped, which assets you are keeping, and what conditions would bring you back to it. Ending doesn't throw away the time you have already spent; it reallocates the time ahead of you to a project you can actually carry out.

*The question to take away: once you stop seeing this project as a choice between continuing and stopping, which is open to you: narrowing, redesigning, pausing, or reusing what you have built?*

## Decision tool: the project status board

Fill in the items below for each project. With several projects, make one copy of the same table for each of them.

| Item                     | Your entry |
|--------------------------|------------|
| Current stage            |            |
| Next action I can finish |            |
| Who owns that action     |            |
| Next check-in date       |            |

| Item                              | Your entry |
|-----------------------------------|------------|
| Target journal or audience        |            |
| Biggest risk                      |            |
| Minimum condition for continuing  |            |
| Condition for stopping or pausing |            |

### What to do now

1. Give every project a single current stage.
2. Choose at most two projects to move one stage this week.
3. On a co-authored project, put the roles, the author order, and what you have agreed on for the next deadline in writing.

## 5. Whose Advice, and How Far

Advisors, mentors, peers, and reviewers all speak from different experience and different authority. The difficulty shows up when two pieces of advice conflict. You may want to do what someone you respect tells you and then find that it doesn't fit your circumstances, or, in the other direction, you may guard your autonomy so carefully that a warning you needed goes straight past you. This chapter is about hearing advice well without handing over the decision.

***The core judgment: alongside what the advice says, weigh the authority the person holds, how far their experience reaches, the reasons behind it, and how well it fits your own conditions.***

### Collect advice like data

At some point I started widening my sources on purpose. When I had a question about preparing for tenure, I did not ask just one person. I also asked other faculty, people a few years ahead of me at other universities, even people outside my field. Patterns came into view. Some advice came back from many people at once; some came from one person only. The first kind is more likely to be right, while the second may be a method that grew out of one person's own experience and suits only them. After that I began handling advice like data drawn from more than one source instead of taking it as the right answer.

Set out as a principle, it comes to this. Check whether other people say something similar, and don't stop at counting heads. Advice from the same department, the same advising lineage, and the same generation can amount to a single local practice repeated by several people. You learn more by crossing it with people at other institutions and other career stages, and with someone who went through that decision recently. Advice from a senior colleague you admire, or from a mentor you're close to, is the easiest kind to take on without testing it. All of it is worth thinking through critically before you follow it.

In practice, the advice many people repeat often takes a shape that would apply to anyone, along the lines of "the narrative matters." Advice that names a specific method, writing at the same hour every day for instance, is more likely a personal optimum that came out of that person's daily rhythm or their appetite for risk.

Even so, don't settle it by simple majority. A minority view deserves weight when it comes from someone with a lot of relevant experience, and the decision at the end rests on your goals, your resources, and how much risk you can carry. The experience behind any piece of advice has limits, so ask as well whether the person giving it went through this problem recently, and whether the path that worked for them can still be repeated now.

#### **Short case: five people giving the same advice can be one vote**

*Case type: hypothetical*

Say you asked five people and all five recommended the same journal. At first it looks like an overwhelming consensus. Now say all five trained in the same program, started their doctorates around the same time, and work with the same methodology. Ask a researcher who uses different methods, and someone with recent editorial experience, and the answer may come back that a different journal suits this manuscript's data and contribution better.

None of that makes the first recommendation wrong. The five answers just weren't independent enough of one another. Observations from different vantage points give you more information than a bigger pile of advice.

*The question to take away: did the advice you've collected come from experiences independent of each other, or is it one practice repeated through several people?*

#### **Separate authority, advice, and your own decisions**

Much of the conflict comes from taking advice as though it carried authority, or from treating a matter that belongs to someone else's authority as one more opinion. So it helps to sort your decisions into three domains.

Some matters are matters of authority, and there you follow: getting the dissertation approved, degree requirements, sign-off on the composition of your committee, the research direction of a funded project where your advisor is the PI, research ethics, and anything touching the IRB. There is not much room for negotiation here.

Other matters are matters of advice, which you consider seriously and then decide yourself: which paper to write first, which journal a solo-authored paper goes to, how to frame your job talk, when to go on the job market.

And some matters are entirely yours: how you manage your time, how you network, how you use social media, the hours and the places where you work.

The middle ground is the hard part. Say your solo-authored paper has been recommended to journal A and you think B fits it better. Ask why A, hear out your other mentors, compare what the two journals have published lately, and then make the call yourself. It goes much the same way when your advisor tells you to stay away from a particular conference. Work out first whether the objection is about funding, about time, or about the quality of the conference, and address the reason you find. Dropping the plan the moment you meet resistance and pushing it through regardless are both unhelpful.

How far an advisor's authority reaches in the first place differs by field and by funding structure, and that's worth holding in mind as well.

The way you decline matters too. "Here's what I'd like to try, and here's why. What do you think?" works better than a flat no. You take it into conversation, politely, with your reasons in hand. Advisors are people and they can be wrong, and if one mentor tells you to open a talk with the theoretical puzzle while another tells you to open with the empirical case, both are right for some situation and some audience. The relationship with your advisor matters, but keeping it is not the same as giving up your own judgment. Your advisor proposes a road; you're the one who walks it. And your advisor wants you to grow into a researcher who can judge independently.

You may also reach a point where you want to change the direction of your dissertation substantially. A dissertation runs, as a rule, on the plan approved at your proposal defense, so a large departure from it is hard to carry through on your own judgment alone, even when a new finding or an external change is what prompted it. If your advisor or your committee decides the existing plan should stand, or that you need a new proposal, you follow that decision. And the earlier and more honestly you tell them something has changed, the more room you have to work out a solution together.

## Extended case: when your advisor's advice and your own judgment differ

*Case type: hypothetical*

Say you've been advised to send a solo manuscript to journal A. Your advisor sees a wide readership there and a good way to make your name known before the job market. You read the recent articles, though, and B suits your methods and your question better; shaping the paper to fit A would mean changing the core of it substantially.

Start by sorting this into authority or into advice. A solo manuscript of your own is not a degree requirement and not a funded project your advisor answers for, so the final choice sits with you. That's no reason to let the advice go past you. Ask why they recommend A, and compare the two journals systematically: recent articles, review times, and how much of the manuscript you'd have to change.

Ask a mentor at another institution as well, and someone ahead of you who sent out a similar manuscript recently. The opinions split, and you can see why. The people who recommend A weigh broad visibility more heavily; the people who recommend B weigh fit with your methods and your readers. Set beside the time left before the job market and the time and effort a heavy revision would cost, B comes out as the better choice.

Once you've decided, say so. "I understood the advantages of A as you described them. Comparing the recent articles and the timeline, I've concluded this manuscript can hold its core better at B." You keep the disagreement from turning into a question of loyalty to your advisor, and you explain only which criteria you gave more weight to.

*The question to take away: does this advice fall in the domain of authority, where you need approval, or in the domain where you weigh it seriously and then decide? If your conclusions differed, which criteria were weighted differently?*

## Go before it's finished

Many graduate students believe they need some progress in hand before they go to their advisor. It works the other way around. You get the most help by going exactly when everything is a tangle and you can't see the way through: when the research direction won't settle, when you don't know how to start the paper, when you can't choose an analytic method, when you have lost your way in the literature. That early confusion is where an

advisor's experience and judgment show most. Sitting alone with a blocked problem and losing weeks or months to it costs you more.

You do prepare before you go. Bring structured questions instead of a finished result: what you've tried so far, where exactly you're stuck, what kind of help you need. "I've looked at A and B, and I'm leaning toward A for these reasons. Is there a risk I've missed?" is easier to answer than "what should I do?" Bringing a clear question is enough; you don't need a perfect answer.

The other face of the same principle is not to surprise your advisor. Good news or bad news, tell them ahead of time where you can. Announcing a submission date or a graduation plan after the fact comes out of too little communication beforehand. Faculty need to know where your work stands to plan their own schedules, and if you only tell them once everything is finished, the chance to get any help is already gone. The tone is sharing information more than asking permission. Predictability is what builds trust.

### **Find several mentors**

For a PhD, the criteria for choosing an advisor narrow to four. Placement record: have their recent students graduated into the kind of path you want? Constructive feedback, meaning criticism and praise in some balance. Realistic expectations, meaning they treat a dissertation as a project you can finish in two or three years. And accessibility, meaning you can actually get a meeting and they handle the basics, recommendation letters and the like, on time. However famous someone is, they're no use to you if you can never reach them.

However good your advisor is, one person can rarely cover writing feedback, career advice, emotional support, and a network in your specialty all at once. So you need several mentors. Your advisor holds a formal role, signing off on your degree and writing your letters. A mentor is an informal one, and can be another professor, someone a few years ahead of you, or a fellow graduate student. If your advisor is also a good mentor, you have been lucky. When that isn't the case, you can still go and find mentors separately.

A mentor who fits shows it in a few ways: they take your questions seriously, they seem to have a real stake in your success, their criticism is constructive, and they give you their own time. A relationship is something you build, so it lasts when you ask for a specific kind of

review, explain whether the work is still at the idea stage or already a finished draft, keep to the time you agreed on, and follow up afterward with a short note on what you decided and a word of thanks.

Departments and scholarly associations run formal mentoring programs. Other mentoring is informal and forms on its own, with someone a few years ahead of you or with faculty in another department. When you need practical advice on a particular method or subfield in a hurry, going informally to someone who actually uses that method gets you an answer faster than waiting for an assigned mentor. Early in graduate school, when you are still learning the department's culture and need a minimum baseline, formal mentoring is where to start. The workable combination is to take your baseline from the formal side and fill in informally what it leaves out.

Peer networks matter especially over the long run. The people who began their PhDs around the same time as you are the ones who read your drafts, sit through your job talk practice, and cheer you on in a hard stretch. They are also the people you will still be working alongside in the same field ten years from now. A hierarchy can creep into co-authorship with someone senior. With a peer, the collaboration can stay closer to equal.

A research community, in most cases, exists only if someone builds it. That could be a proposal feedback group inside your cohort, or a talk series that draws in several departments. The shape varies, and a first version that isn't perfect is still worth starting, because you can develop it once it runs. The relationship lasts when you contribute as well as take, instead of staying a one-way beneficiary. What you want from networking is a few relationships where you understand and trust each other's work. Knowing a lot of famous people counts for less.

The same posture carries over to email, which is where a relationship usually starts. A subject line should tell the reader what you want before they open it. Your point belongs in the first three sentences, and one email carries one request. Writing to someone for the first time, you open with a formal greeting that gives your affiliation and your position, and when you ask a question, saying what you have been weighing and why raises your odds of an answer. Respect for a busy person's time is what makes the first impression a relationship starts from.

## **Draw a line between information and gossip**

Academia is a small world, and word travels fast. Facts anyone can check, things that help someone's career, changes in the rules, news about funding and hiring, all of that is information. Gossip is speculation about a person's private life or personality, an unverified rumor passed along one more time, talk that runs someone down and does the listener no good. The hardest case to place is word about the atmosphere of a lab or an advisor's tendencies, which can matter a great deal to someone weighing a program or applying for a postdoc. There, how you say it is what counts. Instead of "that person has a bad personality," you name behavior anyone could observe: "the way they talk in meetings is direct," "their feedback doesn't tend to come back fast."

I use three questions of my own. Is this of real use to the person hearing it? Would it be fine said out loud in public? Did I confirm it myself, or did it reach me secondhand?

Reputation carries weight in academia, and a bad rumor, once it starts moving, lasts a long time. Long-term trust rests on protecting both at once: the usefulness of what you pass on and the dignity of the person it concerns.

## **Adjust your distance from harmful advice**

Your mental health and your capacity to make judgments are worth protecting deliberately. If every piece of advice leaves you badly stressed or shrinking back, the problem may lie in how the person giving the advice communicates, or in the message itself. Or you may not have the mental room, right now, to take that advice in. In the first case, reduce contact as far as your situation allows, and secure independent lines of support: another mentor, a member of your committee, a student support office. If the power relationship makes the person hard to avoid, what matters is that you don't carry it by yourself. In the second case, it is better to keep some distance for a while and to separate the times you go looking for advice from the times you don't. That is an important survival skill in its own right.

When a relationship is harmful over time, or you sense a risk of retaliation, this is not something to solve on your own. Check the formal rules, and consult more than one mentor, the graduate program administrator, and independent routes such as an ombuds office or counseling resources. Here again, you protect yourself by keeping a record built

around observable behavior, dates, decisions, and effects instead of around your judgment of the person.

### **Where general advice runs out: discrimination and the risk of retaliation**

Repeated humiliation, being shut out of research opportunities, violations of authorship, discrimination, and the possibility of retaliation are not problems that advice to "communicate better" can solve. Where a power relationship is involved, talking to the person directly may raise the risk instead.

Keep a record somewhere safe: the observable behavior and its dates, any relevant documents, and the effect those decisions had on your research and your degree. Alongside that, identify several channels, including a mentor who is relatively free of a stake in the matter, the director of graduate studies, an ombuds office, a union, and student support resources. If an urgent safety issue or a legal question is involved, use your institution's formal procedures and get help from a qualified professional first.

### **Decision tool: an advice weighting table**

Write down the following for each piece of advice that matters.

| Item                                                                                                   | Your entry |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| The core of the advice                                                                                 |            |
| The formal authority of the person giving the advice (do they have approval power over this decision?) |            |
| Relevant experience and expertise (have they been through this recently themselves?)                   |            |
| That person's own stake                                                                                |            |
| How close their conditions are to mine                                                                 |            |
| Where it agrees with other sources (a common signal, or one person's hypothesis?)                      |            |
| The risk of following it, and the risk of not following it                                             |            |

### **What to do now**

1. Take the question in front of you now and place it in one of three categories: authority, professional advice, or your own decision.
2. If only one person has told you this, check it with two more people who sit in different positions.
3. Before your next meeting, get one page down: what you tried, where you are stuck, what help you need.

## 6. Turning Rejection and Evaluation into a Next Move

Academic evaluation arrives late and keeps its criteria out of sight. The same manuscript can be judged differently depending on the journal, the editor, the reviewers, and the moment it lands. Put all of it down to luck and you lose the information that would have improved the work. Accept every criticism as true and one outcome ends up ruling on your whole body of research and on your own worth. This chapter runs from rejection and revision through the job market and tenure, and it is about turning opaque evaluation into information you can read, and then into a decision about what to do next.

***The core judgment: separate the outcome of an evaluation from any final verdict on your worth, and break it down into the mixed signal it is: weaknesses in the manuscript, fit with the journal, strategy, and chance.***

### Rejection is the statistically normal outcome

The first rejection hurts more than the ones after it. You can know perfectly well that it happens to everyone and still find yourself knocked sideways when it happens to you. Anger that the reviewers didn't understand your paper; doubt about whether you have the talent for this; the flinch that keeps you from opening the comments again. Every one of those is a normal response. Checking the numbers helps a little. Rates vary a lot by field, and by whether desk rejects are counted, but it is not unusual for good journals to reject 80 to 96 percent of submissions. Rejection is, in fact, part of ordinary research life.

Behind a glittering CV sits an invisible CV of failures. One article in a top journal usually rests on a string of rejections, and one large grant on several years of reapplying. From the outside, a successful researcher's CV reads as though everything went smoothly, but if you don't know what stands behind it, you fall into the illusion that you alone are failing this often. Write your own CV of failures, setting down how many rejections came before each success, and you can see for yourself that rejection is common to everyone.

### On the day the feedback arrives, change nothing

In my master's program, a comment in a seminar was enough to make me overturn the direction of the manuscript that same night. A different comment came the following week

and I tore it up again. Three months on, the manuscript sat where it had started. Far from moving forward, I kept returning to the beginning. What I understood later was that being open to criticism differs from following all of it. Staying open, if anything, took having a center of my own.

The method that worked for me afterward went like this. On the day a comment arrives, change nothing. Write it down and leave it, then take it out again a few days later. Once the feeling has settled, the comments you have to follow start separating from the ones worth noting while you go your own way. Reviewer comments get the same handling. On the day they arrive, either leave them unread or read them once and close the file. Don't decide on the next journal the night the rejection letter comes. Set it aside for about a week, read it again, and "this one is right" comes apart from "this one is that reviewer's taste."

That separation depends on knowing your own paper's one-line claim, though. Only when you can state in one sentence what the paper argues can you judge which comments threaten that core and which ones are working at the edges.

After the feeling has settled, sort the comments. Fundamental problems threaten the soundness of the argument, the design, the data, or the interpretation. Necessary fixes hold the core in place and make it clearer. Optional extensions would give you a better paper at the cost of a wider scope. Fit problems mean the manuscript doesn't meet what this journal or this audience expects. Taste means a reviewer is asking for one of several reasonable choices. Points that several reviewers repeated, and points the editor emphasized, come first.

### **The scope of a revision is set by the manuscript's purpose and by your time**

A rejection notice is a single event, but it can carry any of several meanings. The manuscript may not have suited that journal; it may have weaknesses that really do need work; a similar paper may have come out recently and left your timing bad; or you may have drawn a demanding reviewer and been unlucky. Gauging which of these it comes closest to is what makes the next choice clear. If the trouble was fit, it is reasonable to look for another journal without a large rewrite; if the comments named real weaknesses, it is reasonable to spend the time addressing them.

Sometimes you can't take on all of it, even when the suggestions are sound. How much you revise varies with the quality of the comments, and also with what the manuscript is for and when it is due. A major revision is right when there is a real weakness in the central claim or the design, you are aiming again at a journal of similar standing, and you have the resources to revise. When the core contribution holds and much of the criticism tracks that journal's range or its preferences, light fixes and a move to a better-fitting journal may serve you better. A major revision raises the quality of the paper and the odds of placement, but it usually runs from a couple of months to close to six, and rejection is still possible at the end of it. A light revision saves time and energy, but leaving the underlying problem in place can bring the same criticism back, or send you down a tier. With graduation or a job search ahead of you, publishing as it stands may be better than six months spent making the paper perfect; with time to spare, using this chance to turn it into a solidly good paper is also a route. There is no right answer, so it is worth checking which matters more to you right now, publishing fast or publishing better.

A rejection is no reason to drop a tier automatically. When the reason lies in fit with the journal rather than the quality of the paper, meaning a mismatch with the theoretical perspective or the methods that journal favors, a lateral move to another journal of the same standing is possible. It does take confidence in your own work and some slack in your schedule. Review runs for months at each journal, so make a few moves sideways and two or three years have gone by. If you're pressed for time, the surer venue is better. If you're convinced the work is that good, it's worth not giving up on it.

### Extended case: choosing the next journal after a rejection

*Case type: hypothetical*

Say a rejection comes back from a top journal. One reviewer objects to the core theory; the other finds the design good but doesn't see a contribution large enough for that journal's broad readership. On the day the email arrives you leave the manuscript closed. You don't settle on the next journal either.

Two days later you separate the comments into fundamental problems, necessary fixes, optional extensions, fit, and taste. The demand that you measure the key variable a different way bears on how far the results can be trusted, so it goes under necessary fixes. The demand that you add an entirely different theory changes the scope of the manuscript, so it goes under optional extensions. The worry about the broad readership you mark as a question of fit.

The manuscript's one-sentence claim is still standing, and the extra measurement takes a few weeks with the data you already have. So you look at two other journals of the same standing, starting with whichever has recently published work using similar methods and asking similar questions. Instead of redesigning the paper on a large scale, you fix only the necessary analysis and the readership the introduction addresses, and you move it to another journal at the same level.

Last, the resubmission date goes into the calendar first, and you count backward from it to set separate deadlines for the extra analysis, your co-author's review, and the revision itself. What you have built is a procedure that keeps the work moving regardless of how you feel.

*The question to take away: which of these comments threatens the core of the manuscript, and which of them disappear once you change the journal it has to fit?*

To gauge whether a paper is top-journal material, look at three things. In sociology, what counts most is whether the question reaches past one subfield to interest the field as a whole, whether you can answer "so what's theoretically new here," and whether you can show a clear finding with a rigorous design and good data. A theoretical contribution takes the form of proposing a new mechanism, joining separate theoretical traditions, or overturning something everyone had taken for granted. Needing all three is what makes it hard.

## **A revision starts with the response letter**

An R&R means the manuscript has entered serious review. It is no guarantee of eventual publication, of course. It is still good news, and you can let go of the pressure to begin today. Give a day or two to reading the comments slowly and getting a feel for the whole. After that, build the response letter before you touch the manuscript. Break each reviewer's comments into items, merge the ones that overlap, and mark priority and expected time. Drafting a provisional answer under each comment sorts the simple fixes from the strategic decisions. When you disagree with a request, don't brush it aside; write down your reasoning and an alternative alongside it. If you have decided against running an additional analysis, explain why the data you have can't answer the question, or why the question falls outside the scope of the paper.

Working from the large structure down to individual sentences is better, because a change in the argument or the design pulls the introduction, the results, and the discussion along with it. On timing, it is safe to assume about 1.5 times your estimate. And it helps to take the revision as the process of building better research.

Give the manuscript a day to cool before you submit and the errors you missed become visible. Check the journal's citation style, the numbers in the tables against the text, whether identifying information has been removed for blind review, final confirmation from your co-authors, the cover letter, and the in-text citations against the reference list. A small error can damage the first impression more than a big idea helps it.

If you are weighing whether to post a preprint, start with your target journal's policy. Posting works in your favor when competition is intense and staking a claim early matters, or when your field leans toward open science. It is better to hold off if the journal won't consider manuscripts that have been posted, or if the work is not yet finished enough. Policies change, so rechecking the official guidelines just before you submit is the safe move.

## **Break down other evaluations the same way**

The job market, contract renewal, and tenure pose the same problem. You separate the outcome from your own worth, and sort the rest into preparation you can control. What differs is that the unit under evaluation is a package bundling research, teaching, and career

instead of one manuscript, and the preparation runs longer. The story the package tells, the role of solo-authored and co-authored work, what a job talk is expected to do, and how to count backward with publication lags in view are all set out in Worksheet 9.

### **Decision tool: breaking down an evaluation**

Once an evaluation comes back, fill in the items below.

| Item                                                                       | Your entry |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| What this outcome tells me                                                 |            |
| What this outcome alone can't tell me                                      |            |
| The main point several evaluators repeated                                 |            |
| Problems I have to fix                                                     |            |
| Suggestions I'll take up optionally                                        |            |
| Questions of fit with the journal (or institution)                         |            |
| Time the revision needs                                                    |            |
| Next choice (major revision / limited revision<br>then move / hold / stop) |            |
| Date I'll decide by                                                        |            |

### **What to do now**

1. On the day the result arrives, leave the manuscript alone and leave your next target undecided.
2. Sort the comments into fundamental problems, necessary fixes, optional extensions, fit, and taste.
3. Set the scope of the revision and the next target, then put the resubmission date in the calendar first.

## 7. Reading the Rules No One Writes Down

Academia publishes its formal rules, but a large share of the knowledge that actually moves the work gets passed along informally. Documents alone will not teach you which conference to go to, when to ask whom about what, or how to make your research known. And tacit knowledge of this kind works to the advantage of people who already hold networks and cultural capital. This chapter has two goals. One is to stop treating your ignorance of a rule as a personal defect. The other is to turn those rules into an explicit map and widen the choices actually available to you. In concrete terms, it covers where to check the rules you need, which communities to take part in repeatedly, and how to make your research and your working relationships known and keep them going.

***The core judgment: don't mistake a gap in information and opportunity for a problem with your ability; turn tacit knowledge into an explicit map through observation, questions, and repeated participation.***

### I didn't even know what I didn't know

When I first went to graduate school I knew the Korean article database I had used for undergraduate assignments, but I had never heard of Google Scholar. I still remember which senior student told me about it during my master's, because I was grateful. None of this had anything to do with the tool being hard to use. The problem was that I didn't know what I didn't know, so I couldn't ask.

That experience left me with one principle. Every time you enter a new stage, make a list of things to check instead of assuming you already know even the most basic procedures. What are the official procedures and deadlines? How much earlier than those does the real preparation begin? What separates a result that passes from a result that stands out? Who do you ask about what? Which resources go unadvertised but are available if you request them? And what is hard to recover from if you learn about it late?

Check the same item against the official documents, with someone who went through it recently, with the staff member who handles it, and with a mentor. When the answers differ, work out whether you are looking at the rule or at the practice instead of arguing over who is wrong. Many universities, for example, keep a stock of used furniture that lets a

new faculty member save research funds, and nobody tells you unless you ask. Asking once, "Is there anything like that?", opens more doors than you would expect. Plenty of things get covered at orientation and still leave no trace in memory, so when you have only a vague sense that you heard something somewhere, it is safer to recheck it than to wave it through.

### **Tacit knowledge is an access gap**

If the whole explanation is someone's instincts or how well they prepared, the structure drops out of sight. Some people grow up around talk of academic careers. The path from a master's to a PhD to a professorship is easy for them to picture, and someone tells them early that things like grades will matter. Bourdieu called this cultural capital. Which department leads to which career, or what you need to assemble before applying to study abroad, is officially public information, but in practice it circulates freely only inside certain groups. The deeper difference is a "sense of what goes without saying." Graduate school sits among one person's ordinary options and outside another person's imagination. That gap in perception becomes a gap in the choices people actually make, and an early gap in information accumulates over time into gaps in research experience, in relationships, and in results.

Even aiming high requires resources. Top programs encourage students to aim high, and in that environment your horizon and your ambition widen on their own. Students there aim a second-year paper at a top journal. Aiming that high usually serves you better than setting a low target at the outset and compromising easily. There are failures in the other direction too, people who hold out for top journals only and reach year seven or eight with nothing published. Even so, aiming high and then adjusting your sights to what the situation allows often ends in a stronger record than writing only for lower-ranked journals from the beginning.

That atmosphere rests on several years of stable funding and little pressure to graduate. Where the funding is precarious and you have to finish fast, you can't take on the risk of losing a few years to a top-journal attempt. Two students of the same ability will set different targets depending on which program they are in. So aiming high depends on more than will. It depends on having the resources to hold out.

Seeing the structure has nothing to do with cynicism. You look at it so you can name the information you're missing, build the routes of access you need, and stop reading every failure as a verdict on your own ability. Competition produces its own illusion here. Every small result starts to feel decisive, because it seems settled in advance who the "chosen" ones are. Anxiety of that kind is what a fiercely competitive structure ordinarily produces. In years when the outlook for studying abroad or for the job market is bad, that anxiety gets harder to climb out from under. Saying this honestly to peers is often enough on its own to bring the relief of hearing that they are going through something similar. It also helps to keep a separate list of questions you're curious about for their own sake, with no bearing on your record, and to open it now and then; doing that lets you step out of the rhythm of competition for a while.

### **A conference is an investment, so pick one with a purpose in mind**

Plenty of conferences look interesting, and your time and money are finite. Choose on relevance to your research, the chance to present, and what the trip returns for what it costs. Relevance is the hard call. A conference tied directly to your work is an obvious priority, while going to one in another field on a vague hope of unexpected inspiration usually ends in disappointment. How much a presentation is worth shifts with career stage, and for a PhD student a talk that brings back feedback and a few new contacts at once counts for a lot. You get more out of two or three a year, with one or two of them repeated annually until you belong to that community, than out of a thin spread across many. The number varies by field. Where a conference presentation counts for something close to a publication, presenting carries more weight; where journal publication is the center of the field, it carries less.

Big conferences and small ones are good for different things. At a meeting of several thousand, a talk is easy to lose in the noise and networking is hard. At one of a few hundred, the same people come back each year, so faces become familiar and relationships build. Go to one conference steadily for a few years and people remember your name, news of openings reaches you, invitations to co-author arrive, and, more than any of that, you start to feel you belong somewhere. A natural order is to pick one conference that fits your subfield and meets at the same time each year, attend and present for several years until

people recognize you, then take on a role such as chairing a session or joining the organizing committee. In my own experience, the big conferences were where I read the trends and the small ones were where I built relationships. Early in a career the second may matter more. In fields where the large annual meeting is the center of hiring and section activity, the big meeting matters as well.

### **Short case: a small conference over a big one**

*Case type: hypothetical*

Say your budget goes to three big conferences and one small one in your subfield. The big ones let you see the broad currents, but you meet different people each time, so no conversation carries on afterward. At the small one you find yourself showing new results to a researcher who remembers last year's talk, and there's a good chance of an invitation to put a session together the following year.

For next year, you could divide the conferences by purpose instead of giving up the big ones altogether. One big conference covers trends and hiring news; the small one you go back to, presenting and following up afterward. You spend the time where several next conversations can grow inside one community, instead of on a longer list of conferences attended.

*The question to take away: is the purpose of this conference broad information, feedback on a manuscript, or a relationship built by coming back, and what is the follow-up that carries into next year?*

### **Networking depends less on your personality than on how you approach it**

Using a shared school or a shared nationality as the starting point of a relationship can sound calculating, but it does help in practice. In the anxiety of the early part of graduate school, a senior student you have something in common with is far easier to talk to, and that first connection sometimes grows into a more meaningful relationship with research interests at its center. Still, a school tie or an ethnic tie is only the key that opens the door. From there you keep the relationship alive with your own work, and over time you build the confidence to meet people without any such connection. Pass on to the students behind you what you were given, and the cycle keeps going.

Being introverted needs no fixing. It's enough to be able to show up as an active participant when the occasion asks for it. Prepare what can be prepared: a rehearsal before the talk, likely questions with answers ready, a few topics for meeting someone for the first time. Accept that after a large event you will need time alone to recover, and pick the few gatherings that matter and give those your best instead of going to every one. If one-on-one comes easier to you than a group, one long conversation over coffee can be worth more than small talk at a reception. Listening carries its own weight, and real interest in what someone is telling you, together with a good question, leaves a strong impression. What matters is not being embarrassed by your introversion.

A cold email is a particularly good place for an introvert to start. You can take your time over it, and the person reading it can answer when they have room. Any connection you have can go in the subject line, which makes the opening easy; writing to a stranger purely to network is the hardest version, and the one that calls for the most care. To raise your odds, make the subject line specific, say who you are and why you're writing, briefly and plainly, include a line showing that you respect their time, and ask for something concrete they can answer rather than for advice in general. "I'd like to ask for your advice" is harder to answer than "I'm wondering whether a thirty-minute conversation about this topic would be possible." Looking up what the person has been working on lately before you send is the bare minimum. And if no answer comes, you don't have to read it as a personal rejection.

### **Making your research widely known**

Making your research known pays off in concrete ways. Ideas that come out of conversation raise the quality of the work, and new projects, chances to collaborate, and news that circulates before anything is officially posted all arrive through relationships. Early in a career, though, I'd put writing papers and returning to one or two communities ahead of chasing visibility. Once there is more research behind you, you can give talks and take on conference roles, explaining your questions and your contribution to a wider audience. By the time outside evaluation arrives, at tenure for instance, whether researchers in your field know your work becomes part of the environment you're evaluated in.

The order shifts with career stage. Early on, good research and a community you'll keep running into may come first. As the work accumulates, widen the range of your talks and

your relationships. However much exposure you get, weak research turns it against you, so doing good research comes first.

Visibility also means being able to explain your question and your contribution in language the person in front of you can follow. With researchers in your own field, you translate it into a theoretical contribution. With a broad audience, into the phenomenon and what it means. The surest route in the end is steady good research, made known through the channels that suit it, and relationships built on real interest and mutual help.

### **Decision tool: a map of tacit knowledge and routes of access**

Write down one goal you're working toward now, then fill in the items below.

| Item                                                                                             | Your entry |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| The official rule and where to check it                                                          |            |
| When the real preparation has to start                                                           |            |
| A public example that shows the quality standard                                                 |            |
| Three kinds of people to ask (someone who did it recently, the staff member in charge, a mentor) |            |
| The money and time it takes                                                                      |            |
| Connections I already have                                                                       |            |
| Routes of access I need to build                                                                 |            |
| A safeguard for when the information is wrong or late                                            |            |

### **What to do now**

1. Write down three things at this stage that you "should have known" and didn't.
2. Check each one against the official documents, someone who went through it recently, and the staff member in charge.
3. Choose one or two scholarly communities to take part in repeatedly this year, and decide the follow-up action for each.

## 8. Building an Academic Life You Can Sustain

Academic work has no end point. There is always another paper to read, another draft to fix, another class to prepare, another opportunity to apply for. The standard for having done enough is never spelled out either, so resting can itself feel like falling behind. Sustainability means drawing boundaries around your roles and your hours, and noticing early the signals that you need to recover.

***The core judgment: design your research and teaching around a pace you can repeat next semester, rather than around the most you can manage today.***

### Tell a slump apart from a problem with the path

In a slump, if the first conclusion you reach is "this path isn't right for me," a temporary shock can turn into a permanent decision. Three things tell you whether it's temporary. A slump that began right after a specific event, a rejection or a conflict, is likely to be temporary. Outside pressures such as trouble with an advisor or money worries can also carry over into doubt about the research itself. Too little sleep, too little exercise, and burnout put a negative cast on everything. Where you can see factors like these, waiting a while longer usually serves you better than breaking off the degree in a hurry. Two more questions belong alongside them. Has the core work ever interested you? And does the same doubt hold even after your circumstances improve?

What helped me, roughly, was a day or two of guilt-free rest, remembering the enthusiasm I felt when this field first caught me, dealing with whatever external thing was wrong, and sitting in on a conference talk interesting enough to spark something. Honestly, no method reliably ends a slump. Many slumps shift as time passes, or some unexpected good news turns out to be the turning point, but not every hard stretch improves on its own. If a drop in day-to-day functioning and serious mental distress persist, don't handle them as only a question of willpower or productivity. Look into the formal help your institution offers, such as counseling, medical care, or a leave of absence.

### **Where general advice runs out: health and persistent loss of functioning**

Measures such as rest, schedule changes, and exercise can ease a temporary overload, but they do not substitute for medical judgment or treatment. If pain or loss of functioning continues, or if your safety is a concern, finding appropriate professional support comes first, ahead of refining your productivity system.

The terms for counseling and medical care, and for leave and workload adjustment, differ by institution and by insurance. Talk the situation over with someone you trust, and confirm which conditions apply to you with your institution's official resources and with qualified professionals.

### **Separate what you control from the outcome**

You can't control much about review outcomes, hiring results, what other people achieve, or the state of the field as a whole. You do have some control over today's working hours, how finished the manuscript is when you send it, the point at which you ask for help, and which skills you learn. The larger the uncertainty, the more you need small certainties. A whole career can stay uncertain while today's work is settled. Fix the hour you start and the hour you stop, set a weekly goal and a regular time to check in, and add process goals alongside the outcome ones. "Publish the paper" is out of your hands. "Finish the draft and ask two people for feedback" is something you can decide.

Whatever breaks a slump arrives in a shape you can't forecast. An R&R or a funding decision comes when it comes, and some stretches run for months with no news at all. Those are the stretches in which to manufacture small completions on purpose. When the big project jams, pick work you can close: sorting the literature, writing a table note, revising a single paragraph. A small completion won't clear away the large uncertainty, but it does give you the assurance that you're doing what you can do, and it makes the next action possible again.

Uncertainty is hard to carry by yourself. You hold up better when you share where you are with peers in a similar position, ask a mentor for the long view, and keep relationships outside academia that confirm an identity beyond the research.

## **Changing roles takes a learning period**

Moving from student to independent researcher or faculty member enlarges your freedom and your responsibility at the same time. You now settle for yourself what to research, what standard to hold when you give feedback, and how much of the decision to keep when you work with students. The ambiguous spot between supervisor and colleague is the part that feels most awkward. While you're talking an idea through it feels like a conversation between equals, but the final call and the responsibility for it sit with you, and when you think the direction is wrong it's hard to know how to say so in a way that lands without hurting anyone. Mostly you learn this through trial and error.

Knowing every answer on the spot is not what expertise means. It's closer to a set of habits: you structure the question, separate what you know from what you don't, find the information you need, and answer responsibly. As an undergraduate you had a syllabus and an exam scope, so the boundary around learning was clear. Now a new method appears and you learn it from the beginning, and a flood of literature keeps coming. What changed is the quality of the questions more than the amount of knowledge. The question shifted from "what is this?" to "how does this connect to what I already know?" When you give advice, say what range of experience you're speaking from, and be concrete about procedures and anything that can be checked while stopping short of pronouncing on the future.

## **Improve one thing per semester in your teaching**

Take on a course for the first time and you'll want to build every piece of it yourself. But change the learning goals, the readings, the assignments, the activities, and the assessments all in one semester, and the preparation cost climbs while you lose track of which change did the work. I've been told more than once that one new thing per semester is a better pace. Settle first on the essential pieces you can run steadily. Then pick a single thing to experiment with, whether that's the discussion format, the structure of the assignments, how you give feedback, or a participation activity, and write down what came of it.

I learned two principles of course design that matter especially. Write the learning goal in one line first. Once you've decided what a student should be able to do after an activity, you have a concrete outcome instead of an activity that is merely fun. Then build a fast feedback

loop. Quiz retakes, exit tickets, and a short survey show you whether students actually understood the concept, which lets you correct course quickly when you need to.

In social science hiring on the R1 job market, what you can teach tends to count for more than how well you teach it. Being able to carry the required courses competently makes you welcome, and running one or two courses on your own before you graduate gives you a feel for the whole span, from designing a syllabus to steering a semester.

That said, priorities like these differ by field and by type of institution. In research-focused sociology departments, at least, the research record and the fit with what the department needs weigh heaviest. Where teaching carries more weight, the priorities may line up differently.

### **Read comparison and regret as signals**

When evaluations and transitions pile up in the same stretch, other people's results start to read like a prophecy about your own future. Comparison does hand you information you need sometimes, but comparison that never lets up makes you read every choice you've already made and every hour you've already spent as a failure. When regret starts to swell, check the pressure you're under now before you sit in judgment on a past choice. A deadline, an insecure status, and too little sleep can all make you see the past more negatively than it deserves.

Graduate school, and the stretch of preparing to go on the market, are themselves periods that invite that kind of doubt. Your earlier choices may not have been perfect, but if they built questions, values, skills, and relationships, then something remains from that time as well. Often you only recognize later that the experience that looked inefficient was the process that shaped who you are now.

Try shifting what you compare yourself against from other people to your own process. Write down what you finished this semester, what you learned, what you stopped, and what you'll do differently next time. Assess your recovery time and whether the pace can be repeated, along with the output.

## **You have to unravel it before you can knit it again**

I learned to knit while I waited for my defense date, after handing the dissertation manuscript to my committee. The time was there and nothing in particular filled it, and simply waiting made me restless, so I needed somewhere to send my attention. With the needles in my hands, knitting a few rows and pulling them out and knitting them again, it struck me that this was much like writing the dissertation. You make a mistake, unravel it, and knit it again. You learn the pattern, and the piece comes together a little at a time. In that other rhythm I saw the same shape in research. You unravel and rebuild until a form appears, a little at a time, instead of only moving forward in one pass.

Sustainability lives in the room you leave to recover after an overload. For research, secure protected time for the work that matters most; for teaching, cap the preparation hours and build materials you can use again; for administration, batch the handling time instead of reacting the moment something lands; for relationships, keep up ties with people you can ask for help and with people outside academia. And put recovery in as time you claim first, ahead of whatever the schedule has left over.

At the end of a semester, it helps to assess the system rather than the output. Decide what proved repeatable, what demanded hidden overtime, and what you'll cut next semester.

### **Decision tool: sustainability dashboard**

Check the items below against the last four weeks.

| Item                                                                | Yes / No |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Are sleep and basic daily life stable?                              |          |
| Did you actually have protected time for research?                  |          |
| Did class prep repeatedly go over the ceiling you set?              |          |
| Did administration and messages keep breaking your day into pieces? |          |

| Item                                                                 | Yes / No |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|
| Is there someone you can ask for help and share progress with?       |          |
| Could you recover without guilt during the time you weren't working? |          |
| Could you keep your current pace next semester too?                  |          |

If three or more items show a persistent problem, adjust the workload, the roles, the deadlines, and the support before you go looking for a more efficient way to work.

### What to do now

1. Divide a page into two columns: outcomes you can't control, and actions you will control this week.
2. Name one task or habit you won't repeat next semester.
3. Block the minimum protected time for research, teaching, and recovery on the calendar first.

## Worksheets

The decision tool at the end of each chapter is for diagnosing where you're stuck right now. The worksheets are for putting down the actual action, the person responsible, the deadline, and the date you'll look at it again. I built them around questions and tables so you can print them and fill in the blanks. The institutions and practices behind them assume U.S. social science graduate programs and research universities, so check the specific rules against your own institution's official documents.

### Worksheet 1. The first 48 hours after a rejection

Sort what to do and what not to do by point in time.

| When                     | Do                                                                                                                                                                                         | Don't                                                      |
|--------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Right after it arrives   | Read the outcome and note only the official deadlines and the paperwork you need                                                                                                           | Don't revise the manuscript or lock in the next journal    |
| Once the feeling settles | Sort the comments into fundamental problems, necessary fixes, optional extensions, fit, and taste; mark what came up more than once; check which demands conflict with your one-line claim | Don't start a full redesign based on your first impression |
| After 48 hours           | Set the scope of the revision, the next target, and a resubmission date, and build a response table or a revision checklist                                                                | Don't let it drift with no deadline                        |

## Worksheet 2. Advisor / mentor meeting prep card

Fill in the items below on one page and take it into the meeting.

| Item                                                   | Your entry |
|--------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| The one thing to decide in this meeting                |            |
| What I've tried so far                                 |            |
| Where I'm stuck                                        |            |
| Options I'm weighing                                   |            |
| What I prefer right now, and why                       |            |
| What I need from them                                  |            |
| Decisions and next actions to record after the meeting |            |

## Worksheet 3. Project stop checklist

Answer each item yes or no, and keep your reasoning in the notes. If several come back no, consider pausing the project or redesigning it.

| Check                                                          | Yes / No | Notes |
|----------------------------------------------------------------|----------|-------|
| Is the question still important?                               |          |       |
| Can I realistically get the data?                              |          |       |
| Is there a design that can test the core claim?                |          |       |
| Do the resources left and the likely contribution balance out? |          |       |
| Can I set this apart from other work?                          |          |       |

| Check                                                                   | Yes / No | Notes |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------|-------|
| Does it connect to a long-term research program?                        |          |       |
| Do I still want to finish this question?                                |          |       |
| Is there a middle option, like pausing, narrowing, or reusing the data? |          |       |

#### Worksheet 4. Conference selection checklist

| Check                                                | Yes / No | Notes |
|------------------------------------------------------|----------|-------|
| Is it directly related to my research?               |          |       |
| Can I present or get feedback?                       |          |       |
| Is there a research community I need to see again?   |          |       |
| Do the cost and travel time match the likely payoff? |          |       |
| Is it clear of my core project deadlines?            |          |       |
| Is there a follow-up action I'll take afterward?     |          |       |

#### Worksheet 5. End-of-semester review

| Question                                  | Your answer |
|-------------------------------------------|-------------|
| What did I actually finish this semester? |             |

| Question                                                           | Your answer |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| What took longer than I expected?                                  |             |
| What materials and systems did I build that I can reuse?           |             |
| What should I stop or cut back?                                    |             |
| How was the balance among research, teaching, admin, and recovery? |             |
| One thing to keep and one thing to change next semester?           |             |

### Worksheet 6. Talk and Q&A prep card

While preparing a talk that mattered to me, I once built the first slide around an introduction to my research topic. The opening dragged, and the point arrived late. I rewrote the first 30 seconds as one concrete puzzle and one question, and the order of the whole talk changed with it. The hook wasn't decoration; it was a compression device that showed the central tension of the research in the shortest form available.

A good hook is understood inside 30 seconds, stays concrete, and leads straight into the core of the research. You can use a surprising statistic or fact, a concrete observation or case, or a paradox. "67 percent of respondents" has more force than "many people," and the reason is specificity. Still, the number itself matters less than whether it opens the puzzle of your research.

An empirical puzzle is understood right away, though its theoretical depth can take a while to show. A theoretical puzzle makes your contribution clear, but it raises the entry barrier for an audience that doesn't know the theory. Check what kind of venue you're speaking in and what that audience is evaluating, then choose. Sort the questions you expect into claim, data, method, scope, and alternative explanations. For the ones you can't answer, prepare what you would go check before answering.

| Item                                                | Your entry |
|-----------------------------------------------------|------------|
| 30-second hook (one concrete puzzle)                |            |
| What the first screen shows                         |            |
| Core claim in one sentence                          |            |
| Expected question (claim)                           |            |
| Expected question (data, method)                    |            |
| Expected question (scope, alternative explanations) |            |
| How to handle a question I can't answer             |            |

### Worksheet 7. First-year faculty operations checklist

In your first year on the faculty, put your effort into basic systems you can repeat instead of running everything perfectly. Hold yourself to one new thing to try per semester.

#### Short case: not improving everything at once in your first year

*Case type: hypothetical*

Say you want to do all of it well in your first semester as faculty: two new courses, advising, service, and getting your research going again. What happens in practice is that you handle whatever is most urgent that week. You keep producing new course material, the research block slips week after week, and you never record which parts of the prep will still be usable next semester.

The next semester you set a floor for each area. In teaching you change one final assignment and nothing else, email goes into a fixed slot in the day, and student meetings all sit on one weekday. Research stops living on leftover time; you book a protected weekly block first. You haven't optimized every area, but by the end of the term you begin to see which materials to keep and which work to cut.

*The question to take away: which one area am I going to stabilize this semester, and which one am I deliberately leaving at "good enough"?*

| Item                                      | Your entry |
|-------------------------------------------|------------|
| Learning goal for this semester, one line |            |
| One new thing to try                      |            |
| Materials to make reusable                |            |
| Fast feedback loop                        |            |
| Policy on tools and AI                    |            |
| Protected time for research               |            |
| One thing to cut this semester            |            |
| Service                                   |            |
| Advising students                         |            |
| Email and admin                           |            |
| Material for the annual review            |            |
| Relationships with department colleagues  |            |
| Research funding                          |            |

### Worksheet 8. Program offer comparison table

For each program that admitted you, put the official offer and what you confirmed with current students into the same table. On money, compare by whether you can actually live on the amount after taxes and rent, and not by the nominal figure.

| Compare                                     | Program A | Program B |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|
| Advisor availability and number of students |           |           |
| Where recent graduates went                 |           |           |

| Compare                                         | Program A | Program B |
|-------------------------------------------------|-----------|-----------|
| Room for non-academic experience or internships |           |           |
| What options are left if I leave or switch      |           |           |
| International student support and visa path     |           |           |
| Conditions I couldn't live with                 |           |           |
| Next question to check, and who to ask          |           |           |
| Years of guaranteed funding                     |           |           |
| Monthly take-home stipend                       |           |           |
| Tuition, fees, health insurance                 |           |           |
| Summer funding                                  |           |           |
| Typical rent and commute                        |           |           |

### Worksheet 9. Working backward from an evaluation deadline

You can't control the outcome of the job market, contract renewal, or tenure directly. What you can manage is the state of your package and when you get it ready. What follows assumes a U.S. social science research university. For the criteria and the timeline that actually apply to you, check your department's and your university's official documents, and ask someone who went through that evaluation recently.

In admissions there was a safety school; on the job market there is none. Competition is fierce whatever the size of the school, and the outcome turns on whether your research fits the area a department is hiring in. Apply to as wide a range of positions as you can, tune the

package to what each of them expects, and prepare routes outside academia at the same time.

A package is read for the question your studies add up to. The number of papers is only part of what people look at. This varies by field, but a solo-authored paper can signal that you carried the idea, the analysis, and the writing on your own, and co-authored papers can serve as evidence that you collaborated and delivered inside a larger project. Instead of asking which of the two is always stronger, look at which role your package is missing right now.

For application materials, collect several recent cases of people who came through the job market in your field, then look for the patterns in length, structure, and emphasis. A job talk likewise starts from what the audience is evaluating. In the U.S. R1 sociology programs I know from experience, one study presented at length was the common format, though some fields expect a broad research agenda and the links across several projects.

Tenure criteria come out of university policy, the department's judgment, and outside evaluation all at once, so no single number captures them. The more opaque the criteria, the more you work backward from the date the packet is due. Academic publishing can take several years, so you spread the risk. Early on you keep enough time to aim high, and from the midpoint you concentrate on landing the manuscripts in your pipeline as actual publications. This isn't a universal year-by-year formula; it's a way of tying each manuscript's remaining steps to the date you'll be evaluated.

| When                                | What has to be in place by then                                      | What to start now                                                   |
|-------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| e.g. Job market materials submitted | Research narrative and the flagship manuscript connect to each other | Collect recent packages; set a deadline for the flagship manuscript |
|                                     |                                                                      |                                                                     |
|                                     |                                                                      |                                                                     |
|                                     |                                                                      |                                                                     |
|                                     |                                                                      |                                                                     |
|                                     |                                                                      |                                                                     |
|                                     |                                                                      |                                                                     |

## **Closing: A Decision Is a System, Not an Event**

Where there is no right answer, good judgment doesn't come together in one brave decision. It runs as a loop. You gather information, compare the options, test your assumptions with small actions, and update your criteria by what comes back.

What's especially dangerous in academia isn't uncertainty itself; it's reading uncertainty as nothing but your own inadequacy. When a question won't come into focus, what you may be missing is a rule for narrowing questions, rather than research ability. When a project never ends, the missing piece may be a completion condition and a stopping rule, and not your willpower. Being shaken by advice can look like a shortage of independence, when what has happened may be that authority and opinion were never separated. Being flattened by a rejection feels like your own weakness, though the cause may be that you have nothing in place to keep your output apart from your worth.

A judgment system isn't grand. You name the problem precisely, find the information you need to check, decide on an action you can control, and leave yourself a date to look again. Deciding to keep going belongs inside that system, and so does deciding to scale back, to postpone, or to leave.

That said, the same system moves at different speeds from problem to problem. A decision that ripens slowly, like enrolling or choosing a research question, leaves you room to cross-check several people's judgment. An event where the feeling arrives first, like a rejection notice, needs a buffer before the system starts at all. Criteria shift as your career stage shifts, so each time the phase changes, it's usually better to rework the system you already built to fit the conditions you're in now.

The checklists in this book offer one possible way of doing this, out of several. Open the one chapter that fits the problem in front of you, answer a single question, and settle on a single next action. There may be no right answer, but you can still make a next move.

## About the Author

By Jina Lee

Jina Lee earned a BA and an MA in sociology in Korea and a PhD in sociology in the United States. She is a sociologist working as an assistant professor, and she studies the sociology of science and gender inequality. This book grew out of a series she wrote on Threads, looking back on the years from entering graduate school through her first years on the faculty.

## Navigating Academia Without a Map

By Jina Lee

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